

we are not even sure who the customer is. Thus, for startups, I believe in the following quality principle:

If we do not know who the customer is, we do not know what quality is.

Even a “low-quality” MVP can act in service of building a great high-quality product. Yes, MVPs sometimes are perceived as low-quality by customers. If so, we should use this as an opportunity to learn what attributes customers care about. This is infinitely better than mere speculation or whiteboard strategizing, because it provides a solid empirical foundation on which to build future products.

Sometimes, however, customers react quite differently. Many famous products were released in a “low-quality” state, and customers loved them. Imagine if Craig Newmark, in the early days of Craigslist, had refused to publish his humble e-mail newsletter because it lacked sufficient high design. What if the founders of Groupon had felt “two pizzas for the price of one” was beneath them?

I have had many similar experiences. In the early days of IMVU, our avatars were locked in one place, unable to move around the screen. The reason? We were building an MVP and had not yet tackled the difficult task of creating the technology that would allow avatars to walk around the virtual environments they inhabit. In the video game industry, the standard is that 3D avatars should move fluidly as they walk, avoid obstacles in their path, and take an intelligent route toward their destination. Famous best-selling games such as Electronic Arts’ The Sims work on this principle. We didn’t want to ship a low-quality version of this feature, so we opted instead to ship with stationary avatars.

Feedback from the customers was very consistent: they wanted the ability to move their avatars around the environment. We took this as bad news because it meant we would have to spend considerable amounts of time and money on a high-quality solution similar to The Sims. But before we committed ourselves to that